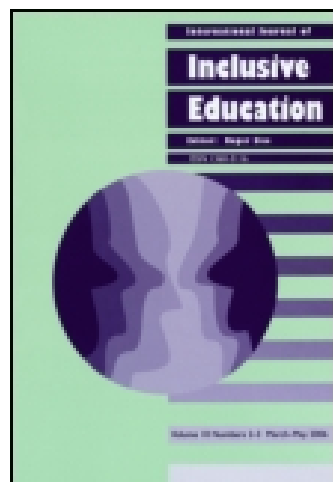


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Autism as metaphor: narrative and counter-narrative

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In this paper we explore the significance of metaphor and dominant cultural narratives in current autism discourse. We briefly explore the history of metaphor in autism discourse, and outline the contemporary struggle between the culturally dominant metaphor of autism as disease and the emergent counter-narrative of autism within neurodiversity. We argue that metaphor serves very specific purposes in autism discourse, including (1) to create a commonsensical narrative congruence between common understandings of autism and currently dominant notions about its aetiology(ies) or causes(s), and (2) to create a commonsensical narrative congruence between common understandings of autism and currently dominant notions about appropriate responses to or interventions for autism. We argue that the bulk of the support for metaphorically framing autism within a disease model comes from within the non-autistic ('neurotypical' or 'NT') community, whereas the bulk of the support for metaphorically framing autism within a neurodiversity model comes from within the autistic community (and is inclusive of some non-autistic allies as well). In exploring these competing cultural narratives, we argue for the crucial import that counter-narrative can play in the process of cultural critique and resistance to ideological hegemony.

Introduction

Susan Sontag wrote in 1978 a seminal essay titled 'Illness as metaphor', and in 1989 a follow-up essay titled 'AIDS and its metaphors' (both published in Sontag, 1990). In these companion essays she explored the powerful and pervasive ways in which the diseases of tuberculosis, cancer, and acquired immune deficiency syndrome (AIDS) had seized the public imagination, examining the metaphors that were commonly drawn upon to describe and in many ways to constitute the experience of having tuberculosis, cancer, and human immunodeficiency virus (HIV)/AIDS. She begins the latter essay by reflecting upon the former:

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Saying a thing is or is like something-it-is-not is a mental operation as old as philosophy and poetry, and the spawning ground of most kinds of understanding, including scientific understanding, and expressiveness. ... Of course, one cannot think without metaphors. But that does not mean there aren't some metaphors we might well abstain from or try to retire.

(Sontag, 1990, p. 93)

I (the first author) first read Sontag's work over ten years ago, and her discussion of metaphor as it relates to disease and, by extrapolation, disability has often informed my own thinking and analysis around these issues, particularly as it relates to the usage of metaphor in autism discourse. It is our hope that this exploration of metaphor in autism discourse may serve to illuminate the complex dynamics of power/knowledge production through discourse (Foucault, 1980). Indeed, we share Foucault's concern with explicating 'regime[s] of truth' and what he calls the "political economy" of truth' (Foucault, 1980, p. 131). According to Foucault:

There is a battle 'for truth', or at least 'around truth — it being understood once again that by truth I ... mean ... 'the ensemble of rules according to which the true and the false are separated and specific effects of power attached to the true', it being understood also that it's not a matter of a battle 'on behalf' of the truth, but of a battle about the status of truth and the economic and political role it plays. ... 'Truth' is linked in a circular relation with systems of power which produce and sustain it, and to effects of power which it induces and which extend it. A 'regime' of truth.

(Foucault, 1980, pp. 132–133)

Thus, in exploring the 'systems of power' which 'produce and sustain' truth, the Foucauldian task becomes one of analysing the performativity of discursive practice. In considering why certain metaphoric statements have emerged in the current historic and material circumstances, we consider not only those metaphors that emerge as dominant or as constitutive of a 'regime of truth', but also those aspects of metaphoric discourse that Foucault (1980) describes as 'subjugated', 'disqualified' or 'excluded'. We seek to excavate not only that which is immediately visible, but more importantly that which is frequently obscured, and to explore the processes by which power circulates in the discursive field in the 'battle for truth'. To that end, we thus consider both an analysis of metaphor in dominant autism discourse, as well as an analysis of circulating counter-narrative to this dominant metaphoric cultural storyline about autism.

In addition to Sontag's literary essays on illness and metaphor, there have been a number of related analyses of metaphor in disability discourse conducted by other researchers. We can see, for example, in the work of the intellectual and political descendants of Burton Blatt a consistent commitment to expose the construct of mental retardation as a metaphor, rather than as a 'scientific' or 'empirical' 'reality' (Bogdan & Taylor, 1976, 1994; Biklen, 1998, 1999; Biklen *et al.*, 2005; Biklen & Kliever, 2006). For example, Biklen & Kliever (2006) recall that 'The most profound lesson from Blatt was his warning that mental retardation is but a metaphor' (p. 174). Additionally, Biklen *et al.* (2005), argues that 'unfortunately, metaphor is ubiquitous

in the field of autism' (p. 36), and illustrates the manner in which 'autism experts' commonly characterize the majority of people labelled with autism as 'being mentally retarded ... without having to prove it' (p. 174, original emphasis). Biklen argues:

In these [deficit-oriented] accounts (e.g., Rapin, 1997; Jacobson, Mulick, and Schwartz, 1995; Volkmar and Cohen, 1985; and Carpenaieri and Morgan, 1996) a metaphor has emerged. Problems in speech and performance are presumed to be based in impaired minds, *as if* the person were held back (i.e., retarded) in thinking. These accounts abandon the reference to metaphor in favor of a deficit-oriented reality.

(Biklen *et al.*, 2005, p. 37, original emphasis)

Thus, Biklen and others in these accounts and elsewhere (e.g., Biklen, 1998, 1999) point to the reification of mental retardation as a clinical reality rather than a conceptual metaphor, and point also to the common conflation of metaphors surrounding autism with those surrounding mental retardation (e.g., the constructs of 'low functioning' and 'high functioning' autism are grounded in the reification of metaphoric constructs of mental retardation). Indeed, Borthwick & Crossley (1999) assert that:

the time may be approaching when the burden of proof will ... shift from those who cast doubt on the explanatory power of the concept of intellectual disability to those who wish to justify it.

(para. 38)

Indeed, these authors raise significant questions about the adequacy, the validity, and the utility of the metaphoric construct of mental retardation:

Any person dealing with a person diagnosed as mentally retarded (or intellectually impaired, or learning disabled) should specifically consider the possibility that the observed disability could be accounted for not by an all-encompassing general difference but by a more parsimonious assembly of particular symptoms — that 'mental retardation' may be, both in any given case and in its wider conceptualization, inadequate as an explanatory concept, undefinable as a scientific entity, and unhelpful as a clinical diagnosis.

(Borthwick & Crossley, 1999, para. 39)

This concept is asserted by the self-advocate, augmentative and alternative communication (AAC) technology, and facilitated communication (FC) communities as well, with the slogan, 'Not being able to speak is not the same as not having anything to say' (Saner, 2007).

This perspective is supported by some of the emerging literature about the autism spectrum and its relationship with the social construct of mental retardation. According to Edelson (2006):

There are frequent claims in the literature that a majority of children with autism are mentally retarded (MR). The present study examined the evidence used as the basis for these claims, reviewing 215 articles published between 1937 and 2003. Results indicated 74% of the claims came from nonempirical sources, 53% of which never traced back to empirical data. Most empirical evidence for the claims was published 25 to 45 years ago and was often obtained utilizing developmental or adaptive scales rather than measures of intelligence. Furthermore, significantly higher prevalence rates of MR were reported when these measures were used. Overall, the findings indicate that more empirical evidence is

needed before conclusions can be made about the percentages of children with autism who are mentally retarded.

(p. 66)

Notably, Danforth and others have conducted analogous explorations and analyses of the uses of metaphor in relation to a number of particularly disability labels, including Emotional and Behavioral Disorders (EBD) (Danforth, 2007), Attention Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder (AD/HD) (Danforth & Kim, 2008), and the particular use of the 'machine metaphor' in autism discourse (Danforth & Naraian, 2007). (For a particularly cogent discussion of the tradition of metaphoric analysis in the field of cognitive linguistics, see Danforth, 2007.) Additionally, Smith's (1999) analysis foreshadows many of the points of the current analysis of autism metaphors. For example, Smith writes:

Within the medical model, metaphors of diagnosis and remediation are privileged (Apple, 1996; Kleinert, 1997; Lovett, 1996; Trent, 1994). People with developmental and other disabilities are seen as being 'broken' and needing to be 'fixed'. This use of a medical, disease-based metaphor maintains and enhances difference, anxiety, and '... threat of contagion'. (Sibley, 1995, p. 25)

(p. 124)

While the present analysis focuses specifically on the use of metaphor in autism discourse, it is clear from Smith's analysis that trends in autism discourse are clearly couched within a very similar and equally troubling context of broader discourses on ability and disability generally.

In recent years, the label of autism has captured the public imagination internationally. Indeed, we would argue that autism is currently a popular cultural obsession in the USA (and increasingly so internationally as well), and that the ways in which autism is currently being (re)invented and indeed constituted metaphorically beg careful critical examination and scrutiny. In the past year alone, autism has received a good deal of popular press in the USA, including featured cover stories in popular news magazines such as *Newsweek*, *Time* and *People*, broadcast television and radio documentaries on a variety of networks including CNN, NBC, NPR, CBS, and coverage in major newspapers such as the *New York Times* and the *Los Angeles Times*. Indeed, it would be difficult to find a popular media venue that has not carried an autism-related story in the past several months (or weeks, or even days), and much of this media coverage has served to reproduce and proliferate the metaphors we analyse in this paper.

In this essay we very briefly present a history of the dominant metaphors that have been drawn upon in conceptualizing autism in the more than six decades since its naming and constitution as a disability label (Asperger, 1944; Kanner, 1943), explore the currently dominant metaphor that is integral to popular autism discourse (the metaphoric constitution of autism as disease), and discuss the relationship and significance of this metaphor to discourse and practices around intervention and policy. We also explore a metaphoric counter-narrative (autism within neurodiversity)

to this dominant cultural metaphor and the narrative that it tells about autism, arguing for the crucial import that counter-narrative can play in the process of cultural critique and resistance to ideological hegemony.

Dominant metaphors in autism discourse

There has long been a common and persistent use of metaphor in popular literature and media surrounding autism, including many pieces of literature that are considered to be seminal or classic works on autism. The content of such literature notwithstanding, even a quick perusal of the titles of many classic works on autism indicate a heavy reliance upon metaphor in the construction of meaning. For example, a series of titles randomly pulled from the first author's bookshelf, whose titles span a publication range of 35 years, include:

- Bruno Bettelheim, *The Empty Fortress* (1967).
- Clara Claiborne Park, *The Siege* (1967).
- Temple Grandin & Margaret Scariano, *Emergence: Labeled Autistic* (1986).
- Judy Barron & Sean Barron, *There's a Boy in Here* (1992).
- Simon Baron-Cohen, *Mindblindness* (1995).
- Bryna Siegel, *The World of the Autistic Child* (1996).
- Jasmine Lee O'Neil, *Through the Eyes of Aliens* (1999).
- Stephen Shore, *Beyond the Wall* (2001).
- Ellen Notbohm, *The Autism Trail Guide* (2007).

We begin with a brief analysis of the common and persistent use of metaphor in these titles as well as an exploration of the cultural purposes that such metaphors have served in recent years.

Autism as foreign space — withdrawal to or arrival from

Spatial metaphors are a dominant type of metaphor that historically has been consistently drawn upon in conceptualizing autism. Indeed, Smith (1999) argues that the 'use of spatial metaphors is a deeply-ingrained human enterprise (Taylor, 1989)' (p. 118), and so this dominance should perhaps not be surprising. Metaphors of space, of geographic separateness, are common throughout many of the titles cited above, and have been common metaphors drawn upon for decades in autism discourse. Two common variations on this metaphor of there being a cultural/geographic space that is somehow traversed in autism are the notions of (1) the autistic person¹ arriving from a foreign space — the metaphor of the 'alien', and (2) the autistic person retreating or withdrawing behind a 'wall' or into a 'shell'.

Arrival from foreign space — 'alien'

The metaphoric use of the term 'aliens' invokes images of arrival, of the person with the label of autism actually coming or arriving from an other, alien, cultural/

geographic space. For example, in the series of titles above, we see authors drawing upon the notions of there being an 'autism trail', and indeed an entirely separate 'world of the autistic child'. In selecting the title *Through the Eyes of Aliens* (1999), author Jasmine Lee O'Neil, for example, appears to be appropriating the common metaphor that she and others like her, who experience autism, are commonly perceived by non-autistic individuals to be 'aliens', people who are considered to be so culturally, neurologically, or otherwise different and distinct from dominant neurotypical conceptualizations of 'normalcy' that persons so labelled are metaphorically considered to originate or arrive from an entirely other world.

This notion of individuals with labels of autism being alien can also be seen illustrated, for example, in Maurice's (1993) description of the process of acquiring a label of autism for her toddler daughter:

We had been thinking of her, in spite of our worries, as a normal child. ... Stripped of our illusions [upon receiving a label of autism for our daughter], we found Anne-Marie to be suddenly alien.

(p. 31)

In thus acquiring a label of autism for her daughter, Maurice dismisses her family's former 'thinking of her ... as a normal child' as an 'illusion', suggesting that they were somehow deceived by her appearance of normalcy, with the implied ontological assertion that she really is 'not normal', instead describing her as becoming 'suddenly alien'. This child, this person who they come to understand as coming from an alien place, is thereby additionally metaphorically excluded from the geographic landscape of what may be considered 'normalcy'.

This particular metaphor has not been entirely limited to what the autistic community often refers to as the 'neurotypical' or 'NT' conception of the autism spectrum, but rather has been drawn upon by members of the autistic community as well, as can be seen in the 'Oops ... Wrong Planet' webpage and the later online community of WrongPlanet.net, both of which draw upon the alien imagery in a fashion that would seem to indicate some level of agreement with the alien metaphor (<http://web.archive.org/web/20050316055307>, <http://www.isn.net/~jypsy/> and <http://www.wrongplanet.net/>). The titles used by each website are indicative of the social isolation that many autistic people face in day to day life, and the general prejudice and discrimination that motivate the autistic community to define itself in many respects according to the separateness paradigm. Further evidence of this can be seen in one of the earliest examples of autistic culture, the Aspergia website, which adopted a mythology to account for autistic differences through 'the lost civilization of Aspergia' (<http://www.aspergia.com/>). 'Each human culture has a mythology to account for its existence, and the way it is. Now we do too?' announced the website, going on to recount a tale about a lost island civilization of 'Aspergians'² (<http://www.aspergia.com>). In this respect, the alien metaphor was co-opted as a means of liberation rather than exclusion.

If all 20 million of us would gather in one place, would we be the 'different ones' then? Would we then be considered to have a 'syndrome' or 'condition'? The first

step to achieving a level playing field is self-determination: deciding that we can define our own identity, and not let diagnostic criteria define us (<http://www.aspergia.com>).

Ironically, given the insistence of the website that Asperger's did not constitute a disability, this formulation seems to implicitly reference the social model of disability concept (Oliver, 1996; Shakespeare & Watson, 1997), noting that disability is a function of environment, rather than a feature intrinsic to the individual. Although the mythology and much of the philosophy behind Aspergia (particularly the 'shiny aspie' concept that 'special abilities' are the primary justification for the anti-cure position) would later be rejected as the autistic self-advocacy movement grew in subsequent years, the focus on discrimination and prejudice as the primary source of problems for autistic people remains constant (<http://autiemomsspeakout.wordpress.com/2006/07/20/making-the-case-for-the-boring-autistic/>).

As the autistic self-advocacy movement has moved into a more civil-rights oriented context, the alien metaphor has been increasingly rejected in favour of more traditional minority group formulations, as evidenced by the frequent references to past civil and human rights movements at one popular autistic self-advocate blog titled 'Whose Planet is It Anyway?' (<http://autisticbfh.blogspot.com/>). Nonetheless, the alien metaphor, while not necessarily originating from within nor currently predominantly favoured by the autistic community, has not been wholly externally imposed upon it, either. The same cannot be said of another dominant autism narrative relying upon the metaphor of a separate cultural/geographic space: that of the autistic person retreating or withdrawing behind a 'wall' or into a 'shell'.

Retreat or withdrawal to foreign space — 'child locked inside a shell'

In the book titles above, for example, we see authors drawing upon the metaphoric notions of there being a 'fortress' (to besiege?) or a 'wall' (to get 'beyond'), of there being a boy 'in here' (in where?), an 'emergence' (whence?) — all of these examples draw upon the metaphoric notion that some sort of substantial if not tangible cultural/geographic space exists between the autistic person and the perception and conceptualization of that experience by non-autistic individuals.

Indeed, early psychogenic metaphors involved the autistic person (usually a child) actively withdrawing from interactions with the outside world. According to Frith (1989):

Autism ... originally referred to ... the narrowing of relationships to people and to the outside world, a narrowing so extreme that it seemed to exclude everything except the person's own self. This narrowing could be described as a withdrawal from the fabric of social life into the self.

(p. 7)

Indeed, Bettelheim's (1967) 'refrigerator mother' theory of autism causation, stating that autism results from mothers who were cold towards their children, is predicated on the idea of autistic children responding to a lack of emotional contact from their

mothers by rejecting and thus retreating from their senses of self. The title of his book, *The Empty Fortress*, would seem to assert this spatial metaphor of separateness. In these formulations, the agent initiating and creating the metaphoric geographic space is conceptualized as the autistic person. The autistic person has gone (whether of his or her own volition or not) to another place, to a separate, spatially removed state, a state of autism, from which, significantly, one might conceivably return.

Cultural purposes of autism metaphor

It seems to us that chief among the variety of possible cultural purposes that autism metaphors have historically served are (1) to create a commonsensical narrative congruence between common understandings of autism and currently dominant notions about its aetiology(ies) or cause(s), and (2) to create a commonsensical narrative congruence between common understandings of autism and currently dominant notions about appropriate responses to or interventions for autism. In order to achieve these twin purposes, dominant narratives about autism commonly draw upon metaphors that themselves rely upon and reproduce a binary divide between cultural notions of 'normalcy' and 'abnormalcy'.

For example, it is perhaps not surprising that these twin metaphoric images of a child with autism either actively retreating/withdrawing to or arriving/originating from a foreign space are entirely consistent with — and have served to rhetorically bolster — much early psychogenic theorizing about the origins or cause(s) of autism. When the 'cause' of autism was conceptualized as psychogenic in nature, it made perfect sense for dominant cultural metaphors to involve the child as an active agent that autonomously, wilfully, volitionally withdrew or retreated, thus creating the cultural geographic space between the child and the rest of the world, whether that retreat or withdrawal was initiated by the child or was a reactive withdrawal in response to inadequate parenting as was commonly charged at the time (Bettelheim, 1967). The now long-discredited notion of autistic children actively withdrawing from the world in a protective response to the emotional frigidity of their 'refrigerator mothers' was made all the more credible at the time by the very conceptualization of autism itself being predicated upon a metaphoric retreat or withdrawal, thus further begging the question, retreat from what? Such a metaphoric conceptualization required some response to this question, and by virtue of sheer proximity, mothers were unjustifiably blamed for 'causing' their children's autism for decades. This is a reflection of the 'retreat' variant of the cultural/geographic spatial autism metaphor described above, establishing the spatial metaphor of purposeful separation and placing the agency of the withdrawal on the part of the autistic person, thereby placing the blame implicitly on the closest possible culprit for motivating such a withdrawal: the parent.

In addition to bolstering dominant cultural beliefs about aetiology or cause of autism, dominant metaphors have served also to bolster dominant beliefs about appropriateness of response to or intervention in autism discourse. Thus, for example, the metaphoric notion of a child retreating from the world into a shell logically

supported the preferred intervention method during the same time period that this metaphor dominated: psychoanalysis for the mother and child. Maurice (1993) critiques the relationship of this metaphor to underlying beliefs about aetiology, but supports its import in relation to actions or response to a label of autism:

Even at the beginning, I never entirely trusted the psychoanalytic idea of a normal child locked within a chosen autism, and today I actively decry that notion and believe it has caused great harm. But in a way, parents who are going to fight for their child do need the construct, however fictional, of that child imprisoned within, waiting to be reclaimed. That child has our committed love. What authority, autonomy, and choice we concede to that child, and when, is another story.

(Maurice, 1993, p. 82, added emphases)

Maurice thus incisively pinpoints the cultural import and necessity of metaphor in autism discourse when she claims parents ‘need the construct, however fictional, of that child imprisoned within, waiting to be reclaimed’ (p. 82, added emphases). Another interesting observation is the assertion that it is the admittedly fictional ‘child imprisoned within, waiting to be reclaimed’, that has parents’ ‘committed love’. The implications of this would seem to reinforce one of the most controversial aspects of the self-advocate ‘autism within neurodiversity’ counter-narrative: that, in the words of Jim Sinclair:

when parents say, ‘I wish my child did not have autism,’ what they’re really saying is, ‘I wish the autistic child I have did not exist, and I had a different (non-autistic) child instead’.

(Sinclair, 1993)

Autism as disease versus autism within neurodiversity

While dominant metaphors in autism discourse continue to be spatial in nature and to rely heavily upon a binary conceptual divide between ‘normal’ and ‘abnormal’, they less frequently conjure up images of [normal] children electively withdrawing, or retreating, or otherwise moving into a separate, even foreign, cultural/geographic space — the ‘land’ of autism. Similarly, current dominant metaphors in autism discourse less frequently conceptualize the person with autism as the alien or the stranger who has arrived from that foreign land, although the latter metaphor has been somewhat more enduring than the former, well beyond the long-discredited theories of autism’s psychogenic origins, quite possibly due to the resonance that the metaphor seems to continue to have with many adults who identify as autistic (e.g., O’Neil, 1999). The metaphor of alien is one that ascribes autism as a central and integral part of an individual’s cultural and neurological identity, rather than as a separate, diseased entity within the person that needs to be eradicated or excised, or from which the individual so labelled needs to be retrieved. Indeed, as explanatory constructs as to the cause or origins of autism have shifted from psychogenic to biological in nature, it is conceivable that the metaphor of ‘alien’ has endured precisely because of its resonance with the emergent discourse of autism as a form of neurological and indeed

cultural diversity. In the shift from psychogenic to biological explanations for autism that has taken place over the past 40 years, there have recently arisen two competing biological narratives for autism: autism as disease vs. autism within neurodiversity. It is interesting to note that the bulk of the support for framing autism within the disease model comes from within the non-autistic (or what autistic people often call the 'neurotypical' or 'NT') community, whereas the bulk of the support for framing autism within the neurodiversity model comes from within the autistic community.

Autism as disease

The single most visible and powerful lobbying organization in the United States that is currently advancing the disease metaphor is an organization that, ironically, calls itself 'Autism Speaks', despite the fact that there is no representation of autistic people on Autism Speaks Board of Directors or in other influential positions within the organization. Autism Speaks was founded in February of 2005 by Suzanne and Bob Wright, who are the grandparents of an autistic child. Bob Wright, at the time, was chairman of GE and NBC Universal, and in the three years since its inception, Autism Speaks has incorporated (literally, corporate-style) two other highly visible autism advocacy and lobbying organizations within its own — the National Alliance for Autism Research (NAAR) and Cure Autism Now (CAN), thus creating the world's largest and arguably most influential and powerful autism advocacy organization.

According to its own mission statement, the organization is dedicated to 'funding global biomedical research into the causes, prevention, treatments, and cure for autism', which is subsequently characterized as an 'urgent global health crisis' (<http://www.autismspeaks.org/goals.php>). By explicitly pledging as its primary goal the funding of biomedical research, it is discursively implied that autism is a disease. This discursive positioning of autism as disease is furthered through the use of the language of 'causes, prevention, treatments, and cure'. These tactics are the province of a disease model — while there are a whole host of neurological or other biological forms of human diversity the aetiology of which one might wish to better understand, it is those differences that are culturally understood as 'disease' that one attempts to prevent, treat, and cure through 'medical' intervention. The disease model is further and more explicitly bolstered by the characterization of autism as an 'urgent global health crisis'. The positioning of autism as a crisis of 'health' further draws upon a medicalized disease discourse in which people who have labels of autism are constituted not as neurologically different, nor even as disabled, but rather as diseased, not healthy, or as ill.

In a 27 November 2006 interview on NPR, Alison Tepper Singer, Executive Vice President for Communications and Awareness at Autism Speaks remarked:

If you have a child that's diagnosed with cancer or another terrible disease, there's an articulated standard of care. A doctor can tell you go see this specialist, go to this hospital, but unfortunately that's not the case with regard to autism.

(On Point, 2006)

By comparing autism to ‘cancer or another terrible disease’, Singer discursively constitutes autism as both ‘terrible’ and ‘a disease’, and sets up the expectation that there should be ‘an articulated standard of [medical] care’ for autism as there is for other ‘terrible’ medical diseases, ignoring the tremendous diversity of the autism spectrum that would seem to invite analogies with either disability or minority ethnic groups as more appropriate and conceivably more emancipatory paradigms. Positioning the dominant discourse of autism within a disease rather than a disability model not only sets up the expectation that a specific medical intervention, or ‘cure’, be the preferred response, but also brings with it a proliferation of militaristic metaphors that are associated with disease discourses. It is these militaristic disease metaphors that Sontag explored in such vivid detail, and that have recently seeped into common dominant conceptualizations of autism as well:

Disease is seen as an invasion of alien organisms, to which the body responds by its own military operations, such as the mobilizing of immunological ‘defenses’, and medicine is ‘aggressive’, as in the language of most chemotherapies. ... Disease is regularly described as invading the society, and efforts to reduce mortality from a given disease are called a fight, a struggle, a war.

(pp. 97–98)

Thus, in extrapolating from Sontag’s analysis and applying it to the current one, we may say that autism is seen as an invasion of a diseased alien entity, to which parents or society must respond by engagement in militaristic intervention operations. Thus intervention is often conceptualized as ‘aggressive’. Autism is also described as having invaded the society, and efforts to reduce occurrences of autism are called a fight, a struggle, a war. The notable difference is that Sontag was talking of diseases that are considered to be lethal. Autism is a lifelong neurological condition that does not affect mortality in any way. Yet in drawing upon these disease metaphors, living life as an autistic person is often metaphorically constituted as being a fate as bad as, if not worse than, death. In fact, at a hearing in the Canadian Senate one parent (a high level official in the Autism Society of Canada) compared autism unfavourably to a terminal illness stating that, ‘Autism is worse than cancer in many ways, because the person with autism has a normal life span. The problem is with you for a lifetime’ (http://www.parl.gc.ca/37/2/parlbus/commbus/senate/Com-e/soci-e/09ev-e.htm?Language=E&Parl=37&Ses=2&comm_id=47 and <http://autismdiva.blogspot.com/2005/06/autistic-success.html>).

Autism within neurodiversity

Smith (1999) asserts that because the discourse of ability is centred through narratives of professionalized, positivist science, counter-narratives are required to inhabit marginalized territories’ (p. 124). Nevertheless, there is a strong and ever-growing self-advocacy movement among the autistic community, the community consisting of autistic people specifically rather than those who often claim to speak on behalf of them/us. These individuals and a growing number of self-advocacy organizations

are successfully challenging the cultural dominance of organizations such as Autism Speaks and the metaphors and cultural meanings that such organizations continually assert and impose upon the public imagination and consciousness and upon individuals who have been labelled with autism or who identify as autistic. These organizations include The Autistic Self Advocacy Network (<http://www.autisticadvocacy.org>), Autism Network International (<http://ani.autistics.org>), the Autism National Committee (AUTCOM) (<http://www.autcom.org>), The Autism Acceptance Project (<http://www.taaproject.com/>), and Aspies for Freedom (<http://www.aspiesforfreedom.com>), among others. Perhaps the single most important contribution that this self-advocacy movement has made to the cultural and metaphoric war (if we may indulge in a military metaphor of our own) currently being waged over the meanings of autism is the construct of neurodiversity.

I (second author, President of the Autistic Self-Advocacy Network), discuss elsewhere the construct of neurodiversity:

The essence of neurodiversity, or neurological diversity, is the idea that the paradigm of acceptance extended towards racial, religious and other similar differences should apply to neurology as well. A relatively new concept, the term originates from conversations held amongst individuals on the autism spectrum in various discussion boards, listservs and other areas of community interaction in the fledgling autistic community. Groups like Autism Network International and, more recently, the Autistic Self Advocacy Network, advocate a new conception of neurological difference along a social rather than a medical paradigm.

(http://www.autisticadvocacy.org/uploads/smartsection/19_Neurodiversity_and_the_Autistic_Community.doc)

In the above referenced piece, I further discuss the rhetoric of disease versus difference in relation to autism, squarely positioning autism within social, cultural, and political discourse, and flatly rejecting the dominance discourse's positioning of autism within solely medical and disease-oriented language and practices.

The term 'neurodiversity' is further explicated on the currently available version of a Wikipedia page dedicated to the construct (<http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Neurodiversity>). There, the construct of neurodiversity is defined as 'an idea that asserts that atypical (neurodivergent) neurological development is a normal human difference that is to be tolerated and respected as any other human difference'. Additionally, it is noted that 'the concept of neurodiversity is embraced by some autistic individuals and people with related conditions, who believe that autism is not a disorder, but a part of their identity, so that curing autistic people would be the same as destroying their original personalities' (retrieved 11 January 2008).

As with any duality, it is productive to inquire as to the reasons why it exists in the way that it does. Why should the perspective developed primarily within the autistic community, whose members might be reasonably seen as the primary stakeholders in autism agenda-setting, be relegated to the role of counter-narrative, while the medical model, disease metaphor achieves such dominance? One possible answer can be found in an examination, not of the positive affirmations of what the autism spectrum is (the source of this current dispute between narrative and counter-narrative), but an

analysis of the struggles in representation that the conflict between them represents. We can pose useful questions about the cause for the division of and possibilities of reconciliation between the stakeholder groups currently behind the predominant narratives and counter-narratives surrounding the autism spectrum.

Like those with many disability classifications, autistic people have suffered and do continue to suffer incredible and shocking brutality — ranging from lethal restraint and quack treatments to electric shock and beating as a means of behaviour modification accepted by the medical and educational communities surrounding autism (Gonnerman, 2007). Yet, despite this, the dominant autism narrative is almost exclusively about family members and their suffering. Why is this the case?

Metaphor, cultural representation, and political power

Representation is established by who can claim control over the narratives used to define a person, place, experience or term, and the parent narrative about autism has had far more time to disseminate than the self-advocate one. In the discussion about autism, autistic people are generally off-stage characters, referred to constantly, invoked with great passion and pomp, but not fit to offer any lines of actual dialogue. The communication difficulties that many autistic people face clearly play a role in why the autistic perspective is not often recognized in the popular narrative surrounding autism. Parents began to form a self-aware community long before self-advocates did, and thus had a head start on reaching the public. It is the natural inclination of every group that wishes to communicate its ‘victim’ status to attempt to monopolize public perception of relevant issues with their narrative and to resist attempts to go off-message in the telling of ‘their’ story. But why do they persist in demonizing autism as an exclusively negative force (a ‘disease’), not to mention marginalizing the autistic narrative of autism (as ‘neurodiversity’)?

Once again, the answer to this phenomenon can be found by looking at the policy of evaluating autistic people on neurotypical terms. It leads to the belief that the eventual goal of all autism advocacy must be finding a cure and thus the idea that any positive discussion of the spectrum diverts valuable public awareness and fundraising support away from that goal while any negative discussion of autism contributes to it. For example, this appears to have been the motivation behind Autism Speaks’ fundraising video, *Autism Every Day*, which featured Alison Tepper Singer, alongside her young autistic daughter, Jody, stating ‘I actually contemplated putting Jody in the car and driving off the George Washington Bridge. It’s only because of Lauren, the fact that I have another child, that I did not do it’ (Thierry, 2006). The macabre and offensive nature of the fundraising film sparked substantial outrage (<http://www.autism-hub.co.uk/autism-speaks-dont-speak-for-me/index.php>). Commenting on why she chose to make the movie, producer Lauren Thierry criticized President Bush for being photographed with a young man on the spectrum who received positive media attention for scoring repeatedly during a high school basketball game: ‘The message Bush is sending is: “Why give funding when all we have to do is find a skill they’re really good at?”’ (Liss, 2006). As Liss puts it, ‘Stories like these send out a

mixed message. Are autistic people all “Rain Man” types who possess extraordinary, superhuman talents? Or is autism a horrifying and incurable condition that pushes families to the edge?’ If these are the only two options, then it is obvious why so many parents view autism representation as a zero-sum game: any positive attention about autism or autistics takes away from the hoped-for public pressure for a cure. By portraying people on the spectrum as tragic and all aspects of autism as horrible, more fundraising dollars can be raised. For this reason, Thierry asked the mothers in her film to avoid maintaining their homes or providing any form of therapy for their children in the days prior to filming. The more desperate the parents appeared, the better the film would fulfil its purpose (Liss, 2006). That this ignores the reality of most autistic people — who are neither ‘Rain Men [or Women]’ nor tragedies — is irrelevant to the ends sought by Autism Speaks and its fundraisers.

It is because of these conflicts over means — such as the desire to raise money for research versus the objections made against misleading or offensive imagery — and over ends — such as the conflict between cure as opposed to acceptance — that there is such struggle over who can claim to speak for autism. The Autism Society of America (ASA) bills itself as ‘the voice of autism’. The popular self-advocate site Autistics.org calls itself ‘the REAL voice of Autism’ as a means of criticizing ASA (<http://www.Autistics.org>). Meanwhile, parents and self-advocates continue to do battle unnecessarily, given the positive contributions each can make to the other group’s individual and collective goals.

In this vein, I (second author) would like to encourage my own community to think strategically about how to approach the divide between the autism and the autistic community. Accordingly, I (first author) would like to encourage the non-autistic community of family members, researchers, educators, and fellow citizens to act as allies to the community of autistic citizens in these endeavours. To drain the swamp of toxic rhetoric from the cure-oriented autism community, we have to pursue two distinct but equally important tracks. The first is to continue to condemn language and advertising that implicitly endorses eugenics. By identifying the results of the culture of despair groups like Autism Speaks spread, we can better capture the attention of the public and turn it against the idea of cure and its proponents, thus moving Autism Speaks outside of the accepted mainstream of public discourse. This is the approach that many disability rights and other civil rights groups have taken in the past. However, while it serves as a useful means of resistance to those groups and individuals that already employ damaging rhetoric against the autistic community, it fails to address the reasons why those groups exist in the first place. As a result of this, it lacks an effective ‘end game’ and, pursued in isolation, will at best lead to a stalemate between the autism and autistic communities. Given the relative financial, political and public relations strength of the cure-oriented autism community, a strategy to address the root causes that lead parents to align themselves with groups like Autism Speaks is needed, for both politically strategic and moral reasons.

The first step in doing that is to advance a positive image of the autism spectrum, as well as to resist and transgress the negative one. How might this be accomplished? The developing autistic culture has provided us with a powerful start in asserting that

while being on the autism spectrum may come with many disabilities, it also includes many benefits and neutral differences, as is the case with any neurological type. Unfortunately, the political and cultural struggles that the autistic community has had to undertake in order to establish the legitimacy of our narrative and perspective on our own neurologies have defined us in large part by opposition. This means that we run the risk of making the same mistake our opponents make in constructing autism by what it is not as opposed to what it is. Yet, despite the necessity of showing what the experience of autism is to people who identify as autistic, there is a gap between knowing that — as each individual on the spectrum does in so far as their own personal characteristics — and communicating that in a cohesive fashion both to the world at large and even within our own community. In this respect, we are hardly alone. Every community struggles with how to define the traits that identify an individual as a part of them, as the many discussions on what it means to be Jewish, or African-American, or gay or lesbian, show. The autism spectrum in its many variations is an ‘invisible disability’ and so we have to work to be able to explain the myriad ways in which it is experienced to those who are not autistic or who are not intimately familiar with someone who is.

In many respects, the best way to solve the previously mentioned divide is to increase the quality of life for families and individuals on the spectrum by improving support for both. As the social model of disability (Oliver, 1996; Shakespeare & Watson, 1997) shows, individuals suffer from disability when the environment around them is not made accessible and accommodating. There remains a long way to go to achieve the goal of full accessibility in reference to the autism spectrum. By promoting meaningful access to Assistive and Augmentative Communication (AAC) technologies, whether independently or via physically supported or facilitated communication (FC) (Biklen, 1990; Crossley, 1994), we can work towards a future where every autistic person has the ability to communicate effectively. By improving public education and funding for transition and adult supports, we can reduce the perceived and actual difficulties imposed upon families. These strategies and many others are not at all unique to the autistic community; they match with the broader autism community’s goals as well. The purposes for pursuing them are both that they both improve quality of life for autistic people and create an environment in which families are not as likely to be drawn to cure-oriented groups that preach offensive rhetoric.

It is ironic in some ways that parents and self-advocates should be so divided, as that they do share many goals for public policy and social change. It is the rhetoric of the autism community — as well as its upside down perception of the self-advocate narrative as secondary to the parent one — that divide the two groups. The autistic community recognizes the adjustment process that parents go through after receiving their children’s diagnoses and learn that the life of an autistic individual can be very different from what parents expected for their child. However, that process must evolve and move forward in time. Without that recognition, the autism and autistic communities will continue to work in opposition to one another while the struggle between the self-advocate and parent narratives continues on — to the great detriment of both groups.

Our goal is not merely to replace a particular 'regime of truth' with another, but rather to explore this particular 'battle about the status of truth' (Foucault, 1980, p. 133) and the 'economic and political role it plays' (p. 133). In exploring these competing cultural narratives, we argue for the crucial import that counter-narrative can play in the process of cultural critique and resistance to ideological hegemony. It seems to us that chief among the economic and political roles that this particular battle for, about, or around 'truth' about autism plays is the popular cultural constitution of a commonsensical narrative congruence between dominant understandings of autism (as disease) and currently dominant notions about appropriate responses to or interventions for autism (including biomedical research into genetic markers for autism that may lead to prenatal testing for autism, thereby reducing the number of births of autistic individuals; as well as the predominant employment of applied behaviour analysis (ABA) as the most appropriate intervention methodology offered to families of autistic individuals). If autism as neurodiversity were a more culturally dominant metaphor than autism as disease, how might it differently inform the political and economic decisions that come into play in the constitution of culturally dominant ideas about appropriate responses, interventions, or supports? We argue that such a metaphor would better support the active mitigation of disablement commonly experienced by autistic individuals as a result of ignorance, misinformation, and discrimination, and that such a metaphor would serve to better support the goals of inclusive education and equal educational, economic, and political opportunities for autistic citizens.

The stakes are high — at stake is the recognition of the fundamental personhood of autistic people, including recognition of the right to exist, to not have future generations of one's community 'cleansed' from the humane genome, to not to be tortured with electric shock and other aversive techniques (Gonnerman, 2007) in the name of trying to cure or 'recover' a person (read: a person's status of 'normalcy') (Broderick, forthcoming), and to have access to educational opportunities that are commensurate to the access enjoyed by non-disabled citizens. It is our hope that the counter-narrative of autism within neurodiversity may serve not only to resist cultural and ideological hegemony by illustrating the political and economic power circulating in the current regime of truth, but also to inform an emergent and more emancipatory regime of truth in which public opinion and public policy around autistic children and adults centres, rather than actively subjugates, the self-representation and self-advocacy efforts of autistic citizens.

Notes

1. Although 'person-first' language was originally intended by many in the disability rights self-advocacy movement to be emancipatory in nature by declaring that individuals with disability labels are 'people first' and that the noun representing the person should be therefore come first followed by a modifying prepositional phrase (e.g., 'person with autism'), this usage unfortunately has the additional problematic consequences of reifying 'autism' as a thing, as well as of drawing upon a medical, disease discourse in its syntax (e.g., a 'person *with* cancer', a 'person *with* HIV/AIDS', etc.), and for these reasons we refrain from its usage, in respect of the preferences of large sections of the autistic self-advocate and neurodiversity community (<http://>

web.syr.edu/~jisincla/person_first.htm). As such, we have decided to opt for identity-inclusive or identity-first language out of deference to the emerging sensibilities of the autistic community. This implies the use of the term 'autistic person' or 'autistic people' rather than 'person(s) with autism'.

2. This particular manifestation of early autistic culture was focused mostly on the population carrying the Asperger's diagnosis and was not as broad-based as the manifestations currently underway through Autism Network International, which from the beginning sought a more 'full spectrum' approach (http://web.syr.edu/~jisincla/History_of_ANI.html). It is interesting to note the use of the alien metaphor in ANI's early history as well, indicating that it is to some extent a natural reaction to the experience of living as a minority in a neurotypical-majority society (http://web.syr.edu/~jisincla/History_of_ANI.html).

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